CITY OF READING, OHIO
COUNCIL MEETING MINUTES – LEGISLATIVE SESSION
July 7, 2026 – 7:30 PM

For the full detail of this evening's Council Meeting, please visit www.watchreadingohio.com.

Opening and Roll Call

The meeting was called to order at 7:30pm by President Mattscheck with an invocation and the Pledge of Allegiance. Council members present: Mr. Powell, Mr. Bronner, Mr. Bishop, Mr. Boehner, Mr. Thamann, and Mrs. Eadicicco. Mrs. Kroeger was absent. Motion was made by Mr. Powell, seconded by Mr. Bronner to excuse Mrs. Kroeger. Motion carried by 6-0 voice vote.

Other city officials in attendance included Law Director Mr. Stevenson, Mayor Mr. Bemmes, and Treasurer Mrs. Owens.

Minutes for Approval

Minutes of the June 2, 2026 and June 16, 2026 Council Meetings were approved. Motion by Mr. Bishop, second by Mr. Boehner. Motion carried by 6-0 voice vote.

Public Hearing – 2027 Budget

- President Mattscheck declared the public hearing open for the proposed 2027 City Budget at 7:32pm.
- Finance Chairman Mr. Bronner summarized the budget, noting:
    - Tax revenues are expected to remain relatively flat in 2026 with modest growth in 2027.
    - State and local government revenues were conservatively budgeted.
    - Charges for services, permits and fines are expected to increase slightly.
    - General Fund revenues for 2027 are budgeted at approximately $11.74 million, exceeding projected expenditures.
    - The Street Maintenance Fund, Capital Improvement Fund, Sewer Service Fee Fund and Fire/EMS Capital Improvement Fund remain financially stable.
    - One ambulance purchase is planned for 2027.
    - Recommended transfers include:
        - $250,000 from the Earnings Tax Fund to the Growth Fund.
        - $200,000 from the Stadium Fund to the General Fund.
- During public comment, Maggie Wilson requested future funding consideration for accessibility improvements, including ADA access to Koenig Park and additional curb cuts around the city.
- There was no further discussion so President Mattscheck declared the public hearing closed at 7:37pm.

Audience Asking Participation

- **Bob Wimmers** addressed Council regarding the proposed Reading Road Road diet. He expressed concerns about increasing traffic volumes, industrial growth, and questioned whether speed is the primary cause of accidents on Reading Road. He also thanked city officials for efforts to attract new industry. Council discussed factors identified by ODOT, including speed, lane widths, roadway design, and pedestrian safety issues.

- **Mark Haeufle** spoke regarding the proposed road diet, raising concerns about traffic backups, turning movements, railroad crossings, utility relocations, side-street traffic diversion, emergency access, and overall congestion. He urged Council to delay the project pending further study. He also recommended increased police presence during scheduled Interstate 75 closures. Council members responded by citing ODOT's traffic studies, travel-time analyses, and ongoing willingness to modify designs based on public feedback.

- **Maggie Wilson** returned to address Council regarding potential traffic diversion onto local streets if the road diet proceeds. She expressed concerns about pedestrian safety along Jefferson Avenue and advocated for increased traffic enforcement rather than lane reductions. She also requested to be addressed by her preferred name rather than formal titles. Council discussed recent efforts to restore traffic enforcement programs and the challenges associated with enforcement staffing and scheduling.

- **Lisa Durbin** thanked the City for publishing a community newsletter but requested that future editions include information regarding the Reading Road project, police department matters, and contact information for city officials. She noted concerns about residents who do not use email or social media.The Mayor and Council responded by outlining the newsletter development process, plans for additional newsletters, and ways residents may contact elected officials.

- **Sue Rinderle** questioned the effectiveness and publicity of public surveys regarding the Reading Road project and asked whether businesses along Reading Road had been consulted regarding the proposal. She also requested additional information regarding traffic enforcement and accident statistics. Administration responded by noting ODOT's outreach efforts to businesses and property owners and encouraged residents to continue participating in City discussions.

Communications read by Mrs. Eadicicco:

- From **Jennifer Dick** regarding Harvest Lane traffic concerns. The communication expressed concerns about speeding, speed bump placement, possible speed-limit reductions, neighborhood traffic safety, and opposition to the Reading Road Road diet proposal. A response from Safety Service Director Ross was summarized, explaining speed bump placement standards and discussing possible future speed-limit reviews and signage options.

- From **David Rodenberg** expressing opposition to the proposed Reading Road Road diet and encouraging Council to reject the project.

- From **Kathy Healy** expressing opposition to the road diet proposal and encouraging increased traffic enforcement as an alternative safety measure.

Guest Speakers

No guest speakers.

Executive Session

No executive session.

Administrative Reports

Mayor's Report: Mayor Bemmes

- A citywide newsletter was recently mailed to approximately 5,200 residences.
- The Water Utility Department has begun implementing electronic billing while retaining traditional payment methods.
- Residents were advised of upcoming Interstate 75 northbound closures and expected traffic impacts.
- The Ohio EPA advised that no environmental issues were found at the former Givaudan site and that suspension of development resulted from business decisions rather than environmental conditions.
- Administration requested Council approval of the 2027 Budget Ordinance in order to meet county filing deadlines.

Law Director's Report: Mr. Stevenson

- No business.

Treasurer's Report: Treasurer Owens

- June income tax collections totaled approximately $752,406.
- Year-to-date collections totaled approximately $5.04 million.
- Collections are currently approximately 4.6% below the same period in 2025, although comparable to prior years.

Council Committee Reports

Finance Committee

- Mr. Bronner reported that the committee reviewed the proposed 2027 budget and recommended its advancement to Council. Fund consolidation options were also discussed.

Utilities, Lands and Buildings Committee

- Mr. Bishop reported on discussions regarding the Reconnecting Communities and Neighborhoods project, with a presentation scheduled for a future meeting.

Zoning, Planning and Environment Committee

- Mr. Powell announced a committee meeting July 21,2026 at 6:30 pm to review Planning Commission recommendations related to proposed zoning changes.

Laws and Contracts Committee

- Mrs. Eadicicco reported on discussions concerning possible expansion of Community Reinvestment Areas (CRA) and future grant-writing opportunities.

Public Health and Safety

- Mayor Bemmes, reporting in the absence of Mrs. Kroeger, summarized June Police and Fire Department activity:
    - 1,015 police calls for service, 28 vehicle accidents, 147 citations issued.
    - 213 EMS responses, 51 fire responses.
    - Additional updates included traffic enforcement efforts, hydrant maintenance, and staffing challenges related to firefighter recruitment and retention.

Service Committee

- Mr. Boehner reviewed numerous public works activities, including:
    - Street and sidewalk repairs, water-main repairs, catch basin work, crosswalk and pavement markings, street sweeping, park and facility maintenance and installation of fencing at Koenig Park.
- Mrs. Eadicicco mentioned that the Civil Service testing for Police Officer positions will be held July 25, 2026, to fill four vacancies. National Night Out will be held August 4 at Koenig Park.
- Chairman Mr. Boehner announced committee meeting on July 21, 2026 at 6:30 pm.

Recreation Committee

- Mr. Thamann reported progress on the new dog park, including grading completion and upcoming fence installation. Pool memberships currently total 592 memberships representing approximately 2,342 individual members.
- Council referred the topic of accessibility improvements at Koenig Park and ADA curb-cut improvements to the recreation committee for discussion. Motion by Mr. Bronner, second by Mrs. Eadicicco. Motion carried by voice vote.

Legislative Session

Resolution – A RESOLUTION SUPPORTING OHIO DEPARTMENT OF TRANSPORTATION'S READING ROAD (U.S. 42) ROAD DIET.

- Council conducted the first reading of a resolution supporting ODOT's proposed Reading Road (U.S. 42) Road Diet project.
- Members expressed differing viewpoints regarding public opinion, safety concerns, pedestrian improvements, traffic impacts, and possible alternatives. No vote was taken, and declared a first reading

Ordinance – AN ORDINANCE AUTHORIZING COMPENSATION TO BRYAN EDENS FOR ACCRUED SICK TIME.

- Mr. Boehner made a motion to suspend the rules requiring a third reading, second by Mr. Bronner to adopt an ordinance authorizing compensation to Brian Edens for accrued sick and vacation leave. Motion carried after a 6-0 roll call vote. Motion to adopt by Mr. Boehner, second by Mrs. Eadicicco. Motion carried after a 6-0 roll call vote. Ordinance No. 2026-19.

Ordinance – THE FOLLOWING BUDGET FOR THE CALENDAR YEAR BEGINNING JANURARY 1, 2027 HAS BEEN ADOPTED BY COUNCIL AND IS HEREBY SUBMITTED FOR CONSIDERATION OF THE HAMILTON COUNTY BUDGEG COMMISSION.

- Mrs. Eadicicco made a motion to suspend the rules requiring a third reading, second by Mr. Bronner. Motion carried after a 6-0 roll call vote. Motion by Mr. Boehner, second by Mr. Bronner to adopt the ordinance approving and submitting the 2027 budget to the Hamilton County Budget Commission. Motion carried by a 6-0 roll call vote. Ordinance No. 2026-20.

Ordinance – AN ORDINANCE AUTHORIZING THE SAFETY SERVICE DIRECTOR TO PURCHASE PERSONAL PROTECTIVE EQUIPMENT FOR THE FIRE DEPARTMENT.

- Mr. Boehner made a motion to suspend the rules requiring a third reading, second by Mr. Bishop. Motion carried by a 6-0 rolL call vote. Motion by Mr. Bronner, second by Mrs. Eadicicco to adopt an ordinance authorizing the purchase of personal protective equipment for the Fire Department. Motion carried by a 6-0 roll call vote. Ordinance No. 2026-21.

Miscellaneous Business

- Planning has begun for the 2026 Holiday Walk and volunteers are being sought.
- Mayor Bemmes expressed appreciation for former officer Brian Edens and recognized his 26 years of service to the City of Reading.

Adjournment

Motion to adjourn by Mr. Boehner, seconded by Mr. Thamann, carried by 6-0 voice vote. Adjourned at 9:10 pm.

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Respectfully Submitted,
Kevin Mattscheck
Clerk of Council, Pro-Tem

Kevin Mattscheck
President of Council